

MBA27 Advanced Strategy

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FACULTY INFORMATION

Name, Title	Dr. Christopher Sabel, Assistant Professor of Strategic Management Dr. Caroline Witte, Assistant Professor of Strategic Management
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Canvas course link	TBD

FACULTY BIO



Dr. Christopher Sabel is an Assistant Professor for Strategic Management at RSM. Besides the MBA elective, Christopher provides coaching in strategy development and structured problem-solving for managers through executive programs. Christopher's research interests focus on resource allocation and investments within multi-business firms as a response to geopolitics and human capital changes. He has published multiple scientific articles in leading academic journals on these topics. Prior to his time at RSM, Christopher worked as a strategy consultant at the Zurich office of Monitor Deloitte and had several academic stops in Norway, Germany, and Denmark.



Dr. Caroline Witte is an Assistant Professor for Strategic Management at RSM. At RSM, Caroline teaches economics to the first-year bachelor students, non-market strategy to the MSc students and a course on international business to executives. Her research interest cover strategy, international business, and development economics. She is particularly interested in how firms manage their business in in fragile economies. Before joining RSM, Caroline was assistant professor at the Copenhagen Business School and worked as an external consultant at the World Bank.

ABSTRACT

In a few years, you may be a corporate executive, a senior manager in a consultancy, or an entrepreneur, which will make you responsible for making decisions in a complex environment. In this advanced elective, we will deepen your knowledge on firm strategy by applying your existing knowledge to contemporary topics in strategic management.

EDUCATIONAL GOALS

The main objective of this course is to deepen your knowledge on firm strategy. This elective builds upon participants knowledge and applies these concepts to contemporary topics in strategic management. The course focuses on 4 distinct content modules:

- (1) **Strategic Problem-solving:** Strategic management can be interpreted as problem-solving. Structured problem-solving is based on deconstructing complex problems (and opportunities) into logical structures of increasingly simple parts, developing hypotheses, and testing these hypotheses by designing and conducting firm-specific analyses. This method and techniques are highly valued and have been successfully used for effective and efficient development of strategy in all types of industries worldwide.

- (2) **Strategy in the Age of Digitalization, Data, and Advanced Technologies:** The fourth industrial revolution is often linked to the trend of increasing digitalization of processes in general and business models specifically. These changes regularly generate new value-generating opportunities across industries. We will discuss how digitalization may alter existing business models and create new business models based on data and advanced technologies, such as the industrial metaverse and artificial intelligence.
- (3) **Non-market Strategies:** The non-market environment can severely limit or enable firms in doing business and has a large effect on firm success. Yet, it is also particularly challenging to navigate since non-market actors differ in their motives, objectives, and tactics relative to conventional market actors. We will discuss how firms can engage in non-market strategies and the benefits and perils of these strategies.
- (4) **Ecosystems, Partnerships, and Corporate Strategy:** The increasing trend toward digitalization is probably best reflected in the rise of business ecosystems that are successfully orchestrated by global players such as Amazon, Uber, and Google. We will discuss the features of business ecosystems with a focus on multi-sided platforms, partnerships that lead to more structured ecosystems, and corporate strategies that lead to building an interconnected ownership portfolio of ecosystem firms.

Learning areas	Educational Goals
I. Content- related	They understand how the emergence of business ecosystems, as well as the digitalization of processes and business models impacts strategy development.
	They understand firm strategy in the context of firm interactions with non-market stakeholders and discuss different non-market strategies
II. Skills-related	They implement structured problem-solving through inductive reasoning.
	They analyse the role of digital technologies and business ecosystems for firm strategies.
	They devise a strategic plan to address advanced challenges in the market and non-market environment.
III. Attitude-related	They gain confidence in translating abstract problems into concrete action.
	They learn how to cope with ambiguity & uncertainty in strategy design.

FIT WITHIN THE RSM ERASMUS MBA AND RELATION TO THE RSM MISSION: A FORCE FOR POSITIVE CHANGE*

Advanced Strategy is a multi-disciplinary course that is founded on ideas from complimentary disciplines such as business, economics, sociology, and political science. By providing the analytical foundations for understanding contemporary strategy topics, the course is complementary to other MBA courses and is the core elective for the Strategic Management Concentration. The course provides participants with the competencies to be a force for positive change when analysing and designing strategies. The course prepares students to navigate issues that relate to the impact of digitalization on a firm's employees and to geopolitical power shifts. In addition, the course emphasizes the importance of corporate social responsibility and political strategies in obtaining and maintain legitimacy in the eyes of market and non-market stakeholders.

* It's RSM's mission to be a force for positive change in the world. For this, RSM is committed to the United Nation's [17 Sustainable Development Goals](#) as the framework for defining 'positive change'. For the RSM Erasmus MBA, we strive to provide our students with the opportunity to master competencies that enable them to successfully lead teams, business units and organizations while they navigate and accelerate transitions towards more just, sustainable and resilient societies. We report the amount of lecture time across all our MBA courses that is devoted directly to such mission-relevant learning. We have further broken this down into environment, social, and governance related topics.

TEACHING METHODS AND WORKLOAD

The course consists of 8 content sessions and 2 presentation sessions. Each session follows a similar structure:

1. We focus on **student-centered learning**, meaning that participants can access materials for pre-session preparation individually to forge their own learning path at their own pace.
2. We focus on **collaborative and active learning**, meaning that participants present and discuss their case assignments with the whole class. This allows for a highly interactive classroom presence.
3. We focus on **challenge-based learning**, meaning that participants work on authentic challenges which may include real-life cases.

Description	Calculation	Total
8 content sessions	8 x 3h	24 hours
8 Class preparations	8 x 2h	16 hours
2 presentation sessions	2 x 3h	06 hours
Preparation final presentation	14h	26 hours
Individual case study	40h	40 hours
4 EC	4 x 28h	112 hours

GRADING AND ASSESSMENT

Course: Advanced Strategy		Assessment formats		
Educational goals per course	Individual case study	Final presentation	Total	
After following this course, students will:				
... understand how the emergence of business ecosystems, as well as the digitalization of processes and business models impacts strategy development	X	X		
... understand firm strategy in the context of firm interactions with non-market stakeholders and discuss different non-market strategies		X		
... be able to implement structured problem-solving through inductive reasoning	X	X		
... be able to analyse the role of digital technologies and business ecosystems for firm strategies	X	X		
... devise a strategic plan to address advanced challenges in the market and non-market environment	X	X		
... gain confidence in translating abstract problems into concrete action		X		
... learn how to cope with ambiguity & uncertainty in strategy design		X		
Weighting factor	50%	50%	100%	
Minimum grade required	5.5	5.5	5.5	
When failed, resit option within academic year	Yes	Yes		
Form of examination	Written assignment	Presentation		
Group / Individual assessment	Individual	Group		

In order to pass the course, each assessment or deliverable (component grade) with a resit option, needs to be at least 5.5. Components with no resit option bear no minimum grade required, but to pass the overall course, the final grade needs to be at least 5.5.

Grades are rounded according to the rounding provisions included in the Examination Regulations (ER) of the programme and are expressed with 1 decimal point. Not meeting the minimum grade required for either a component grade or the overall course grade determines a fail for the course. Participants can resit a failed component only once. There is no capping of the grade for a resit examination, unless determined by the faculty. The only exception is when the nature of the failed assignment allows for an improvement effort of the same assignment (capped at 5.5 for that component).

For this course, the faculty has decided that all assignments are capped at 5.5 and require the improved re-submission of the original assignment.

Grade penalties for unauthorised late submissions will be automatically imposed. Penalties for unauthorised late submissions range from 10% to 20% deduction from the examination component depending on the hours/days late. Unauthorised late submissions 4 days or longer after the deadline without prior notification and a reasonable explanation for the late submission, will not be accepted.

Attendance is mandatory and a requirement to pass the course. Missing classes and arriving late may result in grading penalties and even a fail for the course.

Fraud, Plagiarism / Self-plagiarism (Refer to separate RSM Code of Conduct, Rules and Guidelines, and Teaching and Examination Regulations)

The Examination Board defines fraud as *“the action or negligence of a student because of which it is impossible, entirely, or partially, to form a correct judgment about the knowledge, insight, and skills of them or another student”* (R&Gs and TERs). Examples of fraud are cheating, cribbing, plagiarism, freeriding in a team assignment, availability of unauthorized (study) material during a test such as mobile phones, contract cheating/outsourcing/ghost-writing, unauthorized use of generative AI, identity fraud, theft.

Confirmed cases of fraud/plagiarism will lead to (appropriate and proportional) sanctions as defined by the Examination Board in the Rules and Guidelines (R&G). Repetitive cases of fraud/plagiarism lead to expulsion from the programme.

Plagiarism is presenting another person's work as one's own. Plagiarism includes any paraphrasing or summarising of the work of another person or group without acknowledgment, including submission of another student's work as one's own. Plagiarism frequently involves a failure to acknowledge the quotation of paragraphs, sentences, or even a few phrases written or spoken by someone else.

Using ideas from your own prior work (assignment) without referencing the work in your assignment is considered self-plagiarism.

Participants are required to adhere to the 6 principles outlined in the RSM AI guidelines with regard to the use of Artificial Intelligence Platforms such as ChatGPT and related software/tools. The unauthorised use constitutes violation of plagiarism/ fraud policy. For this course, the faculty promotes an **“embraced”** use of AI.

For more information about academic integrity and AI please refer to the Programme's Teaching and Examination Regulations and RSM AI guidelines documents on the [Student Hub \(Link\)](#).

Assessment / Deliverable:	Individual or group:	(Due) date and hand in location:	% of final grade:
Final presentation	G	5 October 2026	50%
Individual case study	I	12 October 2026	50%

For all Canvas submissions, please make sure to include the student name, EUR student number, and programme name within the document itself (on the cover page), and your initials, EUR student number, and programme name in the title of the file submission

DETAILED COURSE SCHEDULE

Session 1: Monday, September 14th, 2026: 09:30 – 12:30 (SABEL)	
Topics:	Strategic Problem-solving I The 2023 World Economic Forum Future of Jobs report showed that executives perceive analytical thinking to be the most important skill, followed by creative thinking. Regarding future skills, the roles of these two reversed but stayed 1 and 2 respectively, beating others such as technological literacy and leadership. Today, many rush to determine how to tackle “a” problem before formulating the problem itself. This often results in a situation in which the “wrong” problem is solved. In this session, we will discuss how to identify a problem before seeking data, conducting analyses, developing alternatives, and making choices. This will lead to a more structured approach to problem-solving .
In class exercises:	Case-based
Readings:	Spradlin , D. 2012. Are you solving the right problem? Harvard Business Review, 90(9): 84-93. Wedell-Wedellsborg , T. 2017. Are you solving the right problems? Harvard Business Review, 95(1): 76-83.
Case:	Ferrari (618047-PDF-ENG)
Session 2: Monday, September 14th, 2026: 13:30 – 16:30 (SABEL)	
Topics:	Strategic Problem-solving II The purpose of the workshop is twofold. First, we will apply the problem-solving framework to a “real” case. Each group will work on its case company which has been selected for the final presentation. Second, we will discuss how this framework can be translated into a convincing presentation and written assignment. The focus here is on developing a systematic approach to “storytelling” that can guide “consulting”-type of presentations or assignments.
In class exercises:	Case-based
Readings:	Parts of the workshop are based on the book “The Pyramid Principle” by Barbara Minto (ISBN-10: 1292372265; ISBN-13: 978-1292372266). It is not expected that the book is purchased. However, I recommend this book to everyone interested in learning more about strategic problem-solving and how this can be translated into presentations.
Case:	Each group will work on the case company that it has selected
Session 3: Wednesday, September 16th, 2026: 09:30 – 12:30 (SABEL)	

Topics:	Strategy in the Age of Digitalization, Data, and Advanced Technologies I The 4 th industrial revolution is linked to the trend of increasing digitalization of processes in general and business models specifically. These changes regularly generate new value-generating opportunities across industries. In this session, we discuss how digitalization may alter existing business models and create new ones based on data and advanced technologies, such as the industrial metaverse and artificial intelligence.
In class exercises:	Case-based
Readings:	No
Case:	Deutsche Telekom (SM376-PDF-ENG)

Session 4: Wednesday, September 16th, 2026: 13:30 – 16:30 (SABEL)

Topics:	Strategy in the Age of Digitalization, Data, and Advanced Technologies II In this workshop, we will discuss the assignment case, and each team will complete a team assignment on the case. Following the team exercise, a plenary discussion will take place to debrief the case.
In class exercises:	Case-based
Readings:	No
Case:	Deutsche Telekom (SM376-PDF-ENG)

Session 5: Monday, September 21st, 2026: 09:30 – 12:30 (SABEL)

Topics:	Ecosystems, Partnerships, and Corporate Strategy I Firms often sell products which must be consumed together with complementary products, otherwise consumers cannot derive the full value from the offering. Examples include electronic devices such as smartphones, which must be combined with sim cards and apps. In this session, we explore the importance of so-called business ecosystems and discuss how firms can enter them through strategic partnerships and ownership ties .
In class exercises:	Case-based
Readings:	No
Case:	John Deere (TB0702-PDF-ENG)

Session 6: Monday, September 21st, 2026: 13:30 – 16:30 (SABEL)

Topics:	Ecosystems, Partnerships, and Corporate Strategy II Each group will work on the case company that it has selected and try to combine the previous sessions learnings with their case company. We will explore whether individual case companies have ecosystem elements to them or whether they could develop them. Following the team exercise, a plenary discussion will take place to debrief the exercise.
In class exercises:	Case-based
Readings:	No
Case:	Each group will work on the case company that it has selected

Session 7: Thursday, September 24th, 2026: 09:30 – 12:30 (WITTE)

Topics:	Non-market Strategy I The non-market environment can severely limit or enable firms to do business and has a large effect on firm success. Yet, it is also particularly challenging to navigate since non-market actors differ in their motives, objectives, and tactics relative to conventional market actors. In this session we will discuss how firms can engage in non-market strategies and the benefits and perils of these strategies
In class exercises:	No
Readings:	Bach, D., & Allen, D. 2010. What every CEO needs to know about nonmarket strategy. MIT Sloan Management Review, 51(3): 41–48.
Case:	No

Session 8: Thursday, September 24th, 2026: 13:30 – 16:30 (WITTE)

Topics:	Non-market Strategy II In this session we will discuss how recent developments in the non-market landscape have impacted firms' strategies.
In class exercises:	Short case
Readings:	No
Case:	No

Session 9: Tuesday, September 29th, 2026: 09:30 – 12:30 (SABEL)

Topics:	Final presentation session I During this session the first batch of participants will present the findings of their case studies and discuss them with the class.
In class exercises:	Presentation
Readings:	No
Case:	No

Session 10: Tuesday, September 29th, 2026: 13:30 – 16:30 (SABEL)

Topics:	Final presentation session II During this session the second batch of participants will present the findings of their case studies and discuss them with the class.
In class exercises:	Presentation
Readings:	No
Case:	No

ASSIGNMENT DESCRIPTION

Individual case study

Geopolitical risk and tensions are the topic of 2026. Multinational firms cannot avoid integrating the current geopolitical situation into their strategies. Whether firms can buy, sell, and orchestrate their global value creation models as planned is uncertain. In this essay, you are asked to offer an analytical, but creative look into the future.

Answer the question: How might the current geopolitical tensions affect how firms need to think about strategy (in an industry or product-market of choice)?

Try to focus on a manageable scope when answering the question. For instance, focus on a narrowly defined industry or product-market. At the same time, focus on one aspect of strategy, such as for example business models or diversification. While the question invites you to speculate, your arguments should be supported by evidence, such as theories, references, or credible online sources. Do not cherry pick evidence that supports your side of the argument but provide a holistic perspective. Additional information regarding your individual case study will be provided at the start of the course.

Format: Video lecture of 3 minutes. Please upload a video lecture in which you discuss this topic without the support of slides or other visuals.

Final presentation

Your team has been hired to consult the CEO of a company. The company is currently affected by one of the megatrends, e.g., demographic changes, geopolitical tensions, increased social polarization, climate change & resource scarcity, technological change (see www.pwc.nl/en/topics/megatrends.html for examples). You are supposed to brief the CEO and the senior management team on the strategic and competitive threats that the firm faces and the concomitant actions that they should take to combat these threats for the sustained competitive advantage of the firm. A wide variety of formats are appropriate for this presentation, but if I were you, I'd focus on the following questions:

- What are the roots of the firm's competitive advantage? Why has it been as successful as it has been? What are the key factors that sustain that advantage today?
- What are the important forces for change in the firm's strategic and competitive environment? How about changes in the non-market environment? What are the major opportunities? The major threats?
- Who are the firm's most important competitors? Are new competitors likely to emerge?
- Are there other major players, such as complementors and suppliers, whose role may change?
- What would you recommend that the firm does to maintain and/or improve its position? (Be as specific as you can here — the equivalent of “buy low and sell high” or “watch key competitors and take action as appropriate” are not useful.)
- If you were running "your" firm, what would you do? It's fine to make contingent recommendations — if x happens then do y — but please be specific as to the nature of both “x” and “y”.
- Quantify your recommendations clearly. What does this mean in terms of USD, customers, costs, etc.

TASK: Your tasks are to (1) pick **one** real firm to analyze, (2) pick **one** real megatrend to analyze, (3) and to analyze the problems that may develop for the firm in the short-to-medium term and to suggest potential solutions. In order to complete this assignment and to gather relevant information about your company, you can search for relevant business press articles, conduct interviews with company employees, consultants, and industry experts who are familiar with the company. You can also search for publicly available company documents (e.g., annual reports, press statements, conference calls) and resort to any other information sources that you consider appropriate.

The teachers will share a list with companies that are not eligible for the assignment.

GRADING RUBRICS

Individual case study

Criteria	Full marks	Very good	Pass
Logic The main question is answered consistently: How might the structured use of data affect how firms need to think about strategy (in an industry or product-market of choice)	3	2.4	1.7
Use of course materials One or multiple course concepts have been used to analyze the question. They have been used correctly and are the proper tool to understand the analysis	3	2.4	1.7
Structure The assignment is well-structured so that a clear introduction, main body, and conclusion is recognizable. All these chapters also have a logical flow and within-chapter structure.	3	2.4	1.7
Scientific working style There are few language errors and no unclear sentences. The referencing is correct all the time and corresponds to the literature used. All requirements, such as number of words, referencing and formatting are completely accurate.	1	0.8	0.4
TOTAL	10	8	5.5

Final presentation

Criteria	Full marks	Very good	Pass
Logic The company and its problem in relation to a megatrend are introduced compellingly with the course-specific storytelling learnings from day 1	3	2.4	1.7
Use of course materials Learnings from days 1-4 have been used to analyze the firm, its focal problem, and the megatrend.	3	2.4	1.7
Structure The presentation follows a clear and compelling structure that reflects the learnings from day 1.	3	2.4	1.7
Scientific working style There are few language errors and no unclear sentences. The referencing is correct all the time and corresponds to the sources used. The slides are well-designed and can also be understood after the presentation.	1	0.8	0.4
TOTAL	10	8	5.5

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